The Rememberer

By Aimee Bender

ANNIE: My *boyfriend* is experiencing reverse evolution. I tell no one. I don't know how it happened, only that one day he was my *boyfriend* and the next he was some kind of ape. It's been a month, and now he's a sea turtle. I keep him on the counter, in a baking pan filled with saltwater. "Ben," I say to his small protruding head, "can you understand me?" and he stares with eyes like little droplets of tar and I drip tears into the pan, a sea of me.

INTRODUCTION

In a world ruled by intellect, everything sharpens into angles and proofs, and slowly (almost politely) the heart learns to quiet itself. We become so devoted to logic that we begin a kind of "reverse evolution," shedding our compassion, love and relationships in exchange for a more logical precision. And with this shedding comes the dissolution of what makes us human.

Before we notice, we've traded a heart for a plan, and something vital inside us goes dim . . . not extinct, but waiting in the dark for us to remember that a life perfectly reasoned can still feel profoundly empty.

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ANNIE: He is shedding a million years a day. I am no scientist, but this is roughly what I figured out. I went to the old biology teacher at the community college and asked him for an approximate timeline of our evolution.

According to him, the whole process should take about a year, but from the way things are going, I think we have less than a month left.

At first, people called on the phone and asked me where was Ben. Why wasn't he at work? Why did he miss his lunch date with those clients? His out-of-print special-ordered book on civilization had arrived at the bookstore, would he please pick it up? I told them he was sick, a strange sickness, and to please stop calling. The odd thing was, they did. They stopped calling. After a week the phone was silent and Ben, the baboon, sat in a corner by the window, wrapped up in a drapery, chattering to himself.

The last day I saw him human he put his head in his hands and sighed. He was sad about the world. This was not unusual. He was always sad about the world. It

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was a large reason why I loved him. On his last human day, he said, "Annie, don't you see? We're all getting too smart. Our brains are just getting bigger and bigger, and the world dries up and dies when there's too much thought and not enough heart." He looked at me pointedly, blue eyes unwavering. "Like us, Annie," he said. "We think far too much."

I sat down. I remembered how he *once* woke me up in the middle of the night, led me outside to the stars and whispered: ***Look, Annie, look . . . there is no space for anything but dreaming***. I listened, sleepily, wandered back to bed and found myself wide awake, staring at the ceiling, unable to dream at all. Ben fell asleep right away, but I crept back outside. I tried to dream up to the stars, but I didn't know how to do that. I tried to find a star no one in all of history had ever wished on before, and wondered what would happen if I did.

What did I wish for? I wished for good. That's all. Just good. My wishes became generalized long ago, in

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childhood; I learned quick the consequence of wishing specific.

I took him in my arms, my sad man. See, we're not thinking, I whispered into his ear, we're not thinking at all and he pressed his head into my shoulder and held me tighter. Afterwards, we went outside again; there was no moon and the night was dark. He said he hated talking and just wanted to look into my eyes and tell me things that way. I let him and it made my skin lift, the things in his look. Then he told me he wanted to sleep outside for some reason, and in the morning when I woke up in bed, I looked out to the patio and there was an ape sprawled on the cement, great furry arms covering his head to block out the glare of the sun.

Even before I saw the eyes, I knew it was him. And once we were face to face, he gave me his same sad look and I hugged those enormous shoulders. I didn't even really care, then, not at first; I didn't panic and call 911. I sat with him outside and smoothed the fur on the back of his hand.

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We sat on the lawn together and ripped up the grass. I didn't miss human Ben right away; I wanted to meet the ape too, to take care of *him* like a son, a pet; I wanted to know him. . . but I didn't realize he wasn't coming back.

Now I come home from work and look for his regular-size shape walking and worrying and realize, over and over, that he's gone. I pace the halls. I chew whole packs of gum in mere minutes. I review my memories and make sure they're still intact because if he's not here, then it is my job to remember. I think of the way he wrapped his arms around my back and held me so tight it made me nervous and the way his breath felt in my ear: right.

When I go to the kitchen, I peer in the pan and see he's some kind of salamander now. He's small. "Ben," I whisper, "do you remember me? Do you remember?" His eyes roll up in his head and I dribble honey into the water. He used to love honey.

This is the limit of my limits. You don't ever know for sure where it is and then you bump against it and bam,

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you're there. Because I cannot bear to look down into the water and not be able to find him at all, to search the tiny waves with a microscope lens and to locate *Ben*, the one-celled wonder, bloated and blind, brainless, benign, heading clear and small, into nothingness.

I put him in the passenger seat of the car, and drive him to the beach. Walking down the sand, I nod at people on towels, laying their bodies out to the sun and wishing. At the water's edge, I stoop down and place the whole pan on the tip of a baby wave. It floats well…

Ben the salamander swims out. I wave to the water with both arms, big enough for him to see if he looks back. I turn around and walk back to the car.

Sometimes I think he'll wash up on shore. A naked man with a startled look who has been to history and back. I keep my eyes on the newspaper. I make sure my phone number is listed. I walk around the block at night in case he doesn't quite remember which house it is. I feed the birds outside and sometimes before I put myself to bed, I place my hands around my skull to see

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if it's growing, and wonder what, of any use, would fill

it if it did.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Aimee Bender
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AWARD HISTORY

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